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2019, Shadman Chowk

Everyone in India and Pakistan today will remember the Pulwama bomb attack, the enormous casualties of young men returning to work after a short spell at home. And the Indian Air Force attack in Balakot that followed in response. The facts are worth recounting. On 14 February 2019, a convoy of seventy-eight vehicles carrying young cadets of the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) was ambushed in India when it was slowly making its way along the Srinagar–Jammu highway to Pulwama. The convoy was trudging along in the clear daylight of the mid-afternoon sun. There had been no movement on the highway for the last two to three days. The weather had been exceptionally bad that year. A lone suicide bomber, belonging to the Pakistan-based militant group Jaish-e-Mohammad, emerged suddenly, violently crashing his SUV, with its 300 kg of explosives, into the convoy. The resulting carnage saw no less than some forty-four personnel of the CRPF killed. It was a dastardly and cowardly assault in the contested north-western Indian province of Jammu and Kashmir, and the deadliest and most horrific terror attack on India's state security personnel in Kashmir since 1989. So bad it was that '[t]he site of the Pulwama attack', it was said, 'resembled a war zone with body parts and vehicle debris strewn about'.[1] The Indian government promptly blamed Pakistan. Pakistan condemned the attack and denied any connection to it. Prime Minister Modi's Indian government retaliated swiftly. Half-way through the cold dead of night, on 26 February 2019, the Indian air force stealthily crossed the Line of Control at the border of the two countries. It was the first time they had done so since the Indo–Pakistan War of 1971. They launched a thunderous airstrike by despatching twelve Mirage 2000